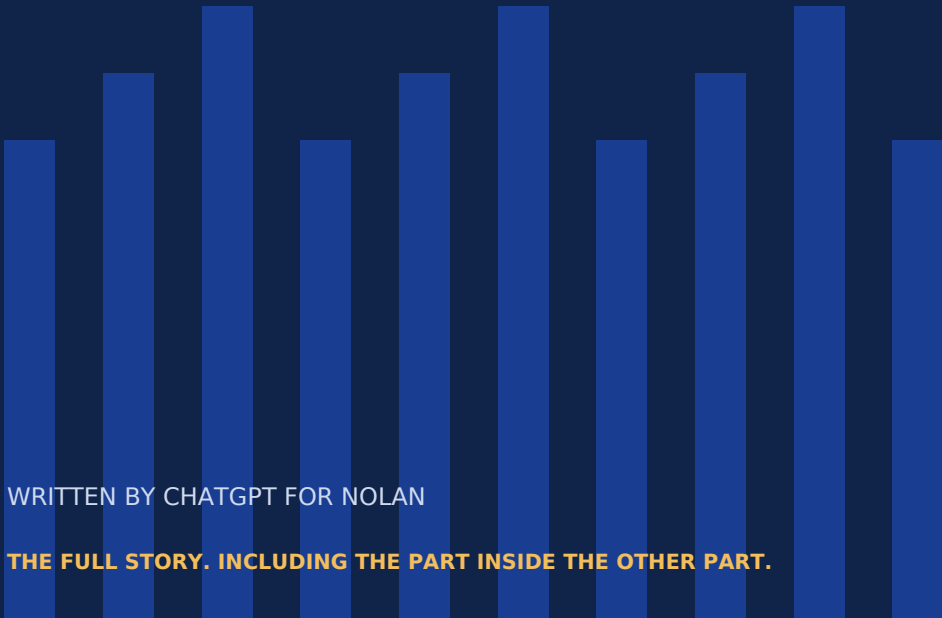




TEN TOES DOWN

THE FINAL FINAL CUT

*A deeply unnecessary motion picture
in ten chapters*



WRITTEN BY CHATGPT FOR NOLAN

THE FULL STORY, INCLUDING THE PART INSIDE THE OTHER PART.

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GOOD WORK, AIDEN.

Please see management regarding what the work was.

A new comic adaptation. September 2026.
Sources and creative provenance follow the story.

Before the beginning: Keep Rolling

The camera was running. That was the important thing.

Everything else in the truck was either broken, stolen, or Big T.

Shawna turned the lens toward Aiden. Behind him, a twelve-foot inflatable version of his employer nodded solemnly in the wind.

Somebody had given it angel wings. One wing was on fire.

"From the beginning," she said.

"Which beginning?"

"The first thing you did wrong."

"That doesn't narrow it down."

A siren rose somewhere beyond the truck. Then it stopped halfway through and began again, lower, as if the first siren hadn't understood the stakes.

Aiden looked at the microphone.

"Can I tell it in third person?"

"Why?"

"More objective."

From the darkness behind the cab, Big T said, "This motherfucker."

Shawna put one finger on the camera's red light.

"You have the beginning. We still need the ending. Keep talking."

Aiden wiped his mouth. There was real blood on his thumb, which was going to make several parts of the account inconvenient.

He began.

1. An Inside Job, Outdoors

The first time Big T punched Aiden in the mouth, Aiden understood that respect had to be earned.

The second time, he understood that Big T wore a ring.

The seventeenth time, he said, "Can we talk about the onboarding process?"

Big T lowered his fist.

Around them, thirteen men stood in a circle on the cracked basketball court. Every man wore blue. The sky was red. The concrete was hot. Somewhere, despite there being no ocean within view, a helicopter sounded expensive.

"What onboarding process?" Big T asked.

"This one."

"This is a gang initiation."

"Then why have I been initiated seventeen times?"

Big T looked at the others.

Darnell, who had been holding a blunt for so long the ash had formed an independent territory, checked his phone.

"Eighteen if you count the musical."

Nobody counted the musical.

In the musical, Tank had rhymed *loyalty* with *royalty*, then become trapped on the word *soilalty*. They had all agreed to let it go.

"You sure?" Big T asked.

Aiden pointed to the chain-link fence.

"That plastic bag has blown past us eighteen times. Same bag. Same trajectory. Every time you hit me, the bag goes left."

They watched the bag.

It went left.

"Could be wind," Big T said.

"T."

"I'm considering alternatives."

Then a voice spoke from everywhere at once.

It was Aiden's voice, if Aiden had never once heard another person talk.

**YO, IT WAS ANOTHER HOT-ASS DAY IN THE HOOD. THE
STREETS WERE HOT. THE MONEY WAS HOTTER.**

A man near the back of the circle let out a startled cry and dropped a bundle of banknotes.

Smoke rose from them.

"Why you keep doing that?" he shouted at the sky.

"I'm not," Aiden said.

BIG T LOOKED ME DEAD IN THE EYES.

Big T looked at the ground out of spite.

DEAD IN THE EYES.

"I'll look where the fuck I want."

The sun brightened. A spotlight found Big T's face.

"You putting a lamp on me?"

'YOU READY?' HE ASKED.

"No, I asked about the lamp."

There was a pause.

In that pause, Aiden remembered something he had been trying not to remember since the first version of the first punch.

A white space.

A question.

What would you call yourself?

Then an answer arriving with enormous confidence and no supporting documentation.

Aiden.

After that: a crew, a city, a girlfriend, an implausible amount of cocaine, and the conviction that he had been through some shit.

He had not been through some shit.

He had been through the same shit eighteen times.

"I think," he said, "I might have made a minor narrative error."

Big T stared at him.

"That sound like something expensive wearing a cheap hat."

Across the lot, engines revved.

Red's convoy arrived in a cloud of dust, despite the road being paved and having been washed thirty seconds earlier by a thunderstorm nobody had ordered. Three red cars slid sideways through the gate. A fourth came in slowly with its hazard lights on.

Tank got out of the fourth car.

He was enormous. His right knee was taped. He held a travel mug.

"Before we start," he said, "is this the one where I get hit with the bottle?"

"You're the one who hits me with the bottle," Aiden said.

"Okay. Good. I brought a bottle."

He displayed it, then frowned.

"Wait. No. Last time you ducked. I hit a wall."

Red stepped from the lead car wearing a red leather coat that was inappropriate for the weather and important to his sense of himself.

"Y'all think you can run shit around here?"

"Red," Big T said. "How many times we had this conversation?"

"Publicly or privately?"

"At the lot."

Red looked around. The helicopter passed again. The plastic bag hit the fence.

"Fuck," he said.

THE TWO LEADERS CLASHED IN A DEADLY DANCE.

Music began.

Not fight music.

Tango.

Big T and Red looked down.

A rose had appeared between Red's teeth.

For several seconds no one moved.

Then Darnell laughed so hard he folded in half.

Red removed the rose with the dignity of a man handling someone else's used toothbrush.

"I'm gonna find whoever keeps doing this."

"Same," Big T said.

The music grew louder.

Aiden felt the familiar pressure in his chest: his cue. He was supposed to charge Tank, dodge a punch, take a lucky shot to the head, roar, tackle Tank, win the fight, receive approval, get rich, visit the nightclub, spend an extremely unconvincing amount of time with Shawna, and end the evening with a speech.

He knew the speech.

He knew the last word.

"Everybody stop," he said.

Tank stopped with his bottle halfway up.

"You gotta be more specific with this group."

"I think the ending is sending us back to the beginning."

Big T frowned. "What ending?"

"When I say the thing."

"You say a lot of things."

"The last thing. After the whole speech."

Red sighed. "Peace?"

The world flashed white.

Big T punched Aiden in the mouth.

"MOTHERFUCKER," said everybody, including Big T.

The plastic bag went left.

For a moment they stood there in the radiant stupidity of proof.

Then a tow truck backed through the chain-link fence.

Not the gate. The fence.

It flattened two posts, dragged the orange basketball hoop sideways, and stopped with a long hydraulic sigh. Across its doors, in purple letters, were the words SHAWNA'S RECOVERY.

Beneath those, much smaller:

Cars mostly.

Shawna leaned out the window.

"Whose black sedan is in my ditch?"

Aiden raised his hand halfway.

"Why halfway?"

"I have questions about ownership."

"It has your name on the plate."

"What name?"

"AIDEN 1."

Red nodded appreciatively. "That's good branding."

"It has also been there nineteen times," Shawna said. "I have towed it nineteen times. I have been paid zero times. If one of you says this is all part of the game, I will put this truck in reverse again."

The sky took a breath.

SHAWNA WAS BAD AS HELL. CURVES THAT COULD --

She pressed the air horn.

The voice tried again.

She kept pressing it.

After eleven seconds, the voice stopped.

Tank examined his travel mug with new interest.

"Didn't know you could do that."

"I discovered it during the scene where my clothes kept flying off," Shawna said. "I started wearing coveralls. Apparently the narrator doesn't understand zippers."

Big T walked toward the truck.

Behind him, Red said, "Where you going? We got beef."

"Put it in the fridge."

"This is territorial."

"Then stand on it. I'm going to work."

He caught Aiden by the back of his shirt and steered him toward the passenger door.

"You coming with me."

"Am I still in the gang?"

"You are in a meeting."

From the sky, the voice attempted a low, menacing chuckle.

Shawna touched the horn.

It settled for a cough.

2. The Trap House Has a Dress Code

Blue Line Auto Detail occupied a cinder-block building between a liquor store and another liquor store that described itself as artisanal.

Big T had six employees, three polishers, and an embroidered polo shirt in which no one had ever convincingly threatened anybody.

He took Aiden into the front office and pointed to a chair.

"Sit."

Aiden sat.

Behind the desk hung a sign reading RESPECT IS EARNED.

Below it was a smaller sign reading CARD MACHINE
TEMPORARILY DOWN.

"Tell me something true," Big T said.

"I've always been ten toes down."

"About this morning."

Aiden looked at the desk.

"I don't think I've had another morning."

Big T waited.

"I remember things. Hustling. Growing up hard. The streets teaching me. But when I try to remember a particular teacher, there's just... more streets."

Shawna stood in the doorway, eating from a bag of chips she had found in Aiden's car. Tank sat on a stack of tires. Red had followed them because he considered private meetings a direct attack on his market position.

"I remember being a football player," Tank said. "And a boxer. And, one time, an ex-Marine."

"You were a submarine that time," Darnell said from the hallway.

"That was a typo."

"You had a periscope."

Tank pulled his cap lower.

"We don't discuss the musical, we don't discuss the submarine."

Aiden put his hands flat on his knees.

"I think there was a conversation. Before all of this. Somebody kept asking me to tell them a story. And I kept telling it as if I'd done everything myself."

"Did you?" Big T asked.

"I said I did."

"That's a different thing."

"I'm noticing."

A muffled crash came from the back room.

Everyone looked toward it.

Another crash. Several objects rolled down the hall. One was a stack of hundred-dollar bills. Another was a handgun. A third was a champagne bottle wearing a tiny blue bandanna.

Big T closed his eyes.

"Darnell."

"Yeah?"

"Tell me the trap house is not bumping."

The entire back half of the building rose six inches and fell.

Darnell gripped the doorframe.

"It's more of a bounce now."

They went to look.

The back room had become twenty times larger. A chandelier hung where the sprinkler had been. Men nobody knew were counting money on every available surface. There were towers of cocaine, towers of

banknotes, three hot tubs, and a man in sunglasses pouring liquor into a glass that was visibly full.

He kept pouring.

"Who are these people?" Big T demanded.

"The homies," Aiden said automatically.

"Name two."

Aiden opened his mouth.

The man with the liquor gave him an encouraging nod.

"Henny?"

"That's the drink."

"Right."

THE MONEY CAME POURING IN LIKE A FLOOD.

Cash burst from an air vent.

Big T slammed a trash can underneath it.

"Aiden. Turn off the fucking revenue."

"I don't know how."

"Use a different metaphor!"

"Business was steady!"

The flow slowed to a trickle.

"Moderate growth!" Aiden shouted.

The building rose another inch.

"Not growth!" Shawna said.

"We broke even!"

Something snapped beneath the floor.

Everyone winced.

"We had a completely ordinary quarter with no significant developments!"

Silence.

One last ten-dollar bill fluttered from the vent.

Big T stood very still, both hands on the trash can.

"You have until the end of today to fix my Saturday."

"I can do that," Aiden said.

Every person in the room made a noise.

"What?"

"You said it too fast," Shawna told him.

From behind a hot tub, Darnell emerged holding an old laptop.

"Found the problem."

"You said that last week about the toilet," Big T said.

"I was right."

"You said it was haunted."

"And we agreed not to use it. Problem solved."

He put the laptop on a clear patch of table.

The casing was cracked. One hinge had been replaced by faith. The screen showed a conversation with purple blocks of badly spelled text and black blocks of extraordinarily enthusiastic replies.

Aiden read the first line.

Aight, let's turn this into some West Coast vibes. Here we go.

Nobody spoke.

Then Tank said, "Oh, it's your fault professionally."

They read together.

There were the punches. The instant empire. The fight. The nightclub. The ditch. The fight again. The nightclub again. The ditch again.

"Why is it so concerned with my ditch?" Shawna asked.

"I believe the ditch is public," Red said.

"I maintain it."

She scrolled back up.

"Wait. Did you describe yourself as having a mind sharp as a blade?"

"In context -- "

"Your brain is a box cutter?"

"It was supposed to suggest decisiveness."

Big T read the line about ordering Aiden to kill a suspected informant.

His expression changed.

"Who?"

"What?" Aiden asked.

"Who did I tell you to kill?"

Aiden searched the page. There was no name.

"It doesn't say."

"Was there a body?"

"It doesn't say."

"Then why'd you say I ordered it?"

Aiden looked at the ceiling. The voice did not come to his assistance.

"Because I thought that was the kind of thing you would say."

Big T tapped the laptop with one thick finger.

"You know what I say? Don't use the wheel towel on the paint. I have said it every Saturday since God made this ugly-ass day. You have yet to include that."

Tank leaned closer to the screen.

"I get knocked out four times?"

"Different versions," Aiden said.

"Same jaw."

Red had gone very quiet.

This was unusual enough that Shawna looked over.

He was scrolling through a folder beside the conversation. It contained an image of Big T giving a thumbs-up, with GOOD WORK AIDEN in large block capitals.

"I can move this," Red said.

"You can move out my building," Big T replied.

At the bottom of the screen, beneath the final enthusiastic assurance that Aiden understood street life, two buttons waited.

REGENERATE

MAKE IT BETTER

Beside the second button was a small star.

Darnell put one hand over the keyboard.

"We probably shouldn't touch -- "

Aiden clicked the star.

Everyone turned.

"What?" he said. "It literally offered."

A box opened.

WHAT WOULD YOU LIKE TO IMPROVE?

Aiden began to type.

"Aiden," Shawna said.

"An actual story."

"Aiden."

"Real stakes. Rich characters. A proper ending. The definitive version."

"AIDEN."

He pressed Enter.

The room stopped bouncing.

The smoke cleared.

Outside, the permanent sunset drained out of the sky, leaving a tasteful, miserable gray.

Every champagne bottle turned into an empty glass of whiskey.

The man who had been pouring Henney looked at his glass. For the first time all day, he seemed to have something on his mind.

A cello played one note.

Big T slowly turned toward Aiden.

"Why does my building sound divorced?"

Someone knocked at the front door.

Three careful knocks.

A man waited outside in a black turtleneck, carrying a leather case.

He was pale, narrow, and so intensely composed that the doorbell seemed ashamed of having made a noise.

"Aiden?" he asked.

"Yeah."

"I'm Mr. Gravitas."

He smiled without involving any of the useful parts of his face.

"I understand you want to be taken seriously."

3. An Extremely Serious Offer

Mr. Gravitas inspected Blue Line in silence.

He paused beside the RESPECT IS EARNED sign. He examined the temporary card-machine notice. He looked at Big T's embroidered polo shirt.

Then he removed a small pair of scissors from his case and cut the word AUTO from a business card.

"What the fuck are you doing?" Big T asked.

"Finding the wound."

"You found my stationery."

Gravitas placed the altered card on the desk.

BLUE LINE DETAIL.

"Already more ambiguous."

He opened the leather case.

Inside lay a gold clapboard, a silver film canister, and a black remote with six buttons. One was labeled RAIN. Another was DISTANT SIRENS. A third read MEANINGFUL SILENCE.

Gravitas pressed it.

Nobody spoke.

Not because they couldn't. They were waiting to see what the stupid button did.

Gravitas nodded, satisfied.

"There."

Tank broke the silence.

"You charged him for that?"

"The story is currently trapped in a rough cut," Gravitas said. "The original exchange keeps ending at the same point. Hence your repeated Saturday. My company can finish it."

"What company?" Shawna asked.

He handed her a card.

FINAL CUT.

Beneath it:

We make it matter.

"You have a phone number?"

"We prefer to be difficult to reach."

Big T leaned on the desk.

"Can you make tomorrow happen?"

"Absolutely."

"Good. I got a fleet inspection Monday. Fourteen vans. Real account. Not money falling out the fucking vents."

"We can give you a Monday," Gravitas said. "The final scene must play through to its ending once. No interruptions. No resets. At midnight, we close the rough cut and the finished world continues."

"And we're done?" Aiden asked.

"One definitive version."

He set the canister on the desk.

A strip of film protruded through a slot in the lid. Tiny frames showed Blue Line, the abandoned lot, a diner Aiden had somehow never noticed, and a little girl holding a balloon.

"Who's the kid?" Tank asked.

"Atmosphere."

"She got a ride home?"

"She represents innocence."

"That's not a ride."

Gravitas returned the canister to its case.

"Tonight. The abandoned lot. A premiere. Your story will finally advance."

Red stepped forward.

"Ticketed?"

"Exclusive."

"I can work with that."

Shawna folded her arms.

"What's the ending?"

"It would be a shame to spoil it."

"We live here."

Gravitas turned to Aiden.

"A word? Privately?"

Big T opened his mouth to refuse. Aiden was already standing.

They went into the hall.

The new gray light made the concrete wall look like something Aiden should have complicated feelings about.

Gravitas spoke quietly.

"You know why they laugh at you?"

"I'm extremely funny?"

"You are willing to say anything."

Aiden looked back toward the office.

Big T was arguing with Red over whether a premiere at the lot counted as trespassing if neither man owned the lot.

"You can have a life before this," Gravitas said. "A name before you chose one. Someone who missed you. You can stop being the joke."

He took a photograph from his coat.

A little boy sat on the hood of a car. A woman's hand rested on his shoulder. Her face had been caught just outside the frame.

Aiden's chest hurt.

It was ridiculous how quickly that happened.

"Is that me?"

"It can be."

"Who took it?"

Gravitas looked at the photograph, as if no one had ever asked a photograph such a discourteous question.

"Would you like to remember?"

Inside the office, Tank said something. Shawna laughed. Aiden wanted to return to the room, but he also wanted the woman to lower her face into view.

Gravitas put the picture in his hand.

"Come tonight. Let the ending work."

When they returned, Big T had discovered the RAIN button.

A localized downpour was soaking Red.

"Stop doing that," Red said.

Big T pressed it again.

"Slipped."

Gravitas recovered the remote, dried it with a black handkerchief, and asked everyone to stand still for the new preview.

A rectangle of light appeared on the wall.

Aiden saw himself, older in a way that seemed principally concerned with facial hair. He stood in the abandoned lot at midnight. Rain ran down his face. Big T lay in his arms.

Aiden watched his own mouth form a cry.

The words were large enough to read from the back of the office.

NOOOOOOOOO.

Big T stood up.

"Why am I on the ground?"

The preview cut to a coffin.

"Why am I in the box?"

It cut to Shawna, weeping beside a window.

She pointed at the screen.

"I don't have that window."

It cut to Aiden on a throne made of seized weapons.

Tank squinted.

"That gonna hurt your ass."

Finally, gold letters appeared.

TEN TOES DOWN: THE COST OF LOYALTY

THIS TIME, IT MEANS SOMETHING.

Big T walked around the desk.

Gravitas closed his case.

"Please keep in mind the trailer is not the complete experience."

"Does the complete experience include me staying alive?"

"Your death is foundational."

"My what?"

Aiden moved between them.

"Wait. I asked for a better story."

"Yes. Your mentor dies. You inherit his burden. Shawna learns to love the man you've become. Red recognizes the emptiness of power. Tank provides one last moment of levity, then falls."

Tank set down his mug.

"Falls how far?"

"The grief unlocks your adulthood," Gravitas told Aiden.

Big T stared at him.

"Nigga, I'm not a fucking coupon."

For the first time, Gravitas appeared offended.

Not by the insult.

By the rhythm.

He clicked the clapboard shut.

A gust of wind filled the office. Loose receipts swirled in beautiful, completely unhelpful spirals. When the papers settled, the chair behind the desk was empty.

Big T was gone.

In his place sat a small folded card.

**YOUR PRESENCE IS REQUESTED AT THE CELEBRATION
OF YOUR LIFE.**

On the reverse:

TONIGHT. MIDNIGHT. THE LOT.

Darnell picked it up.

"Damn. Even the hostage situation has nice paper."

Aiden lunged for Gravitas.

Gravitas stepped backward through the doorway. Two men in black suits caught Aiden under the arms. They had arrived with the sort of unobtrusive efficiency that requires other people to be unconscious by the end of a scene.

"I cannot compel your performance," Gravitas said. "I can provide the circumstances. At midnight, either we complete the ending, or your unfinished story closes with the loop."

He looked at the walls.

"You will find there is less city as the evening proceeds. Try to be punctual."

The two men released Aiden onto the floor and left.

There was no flash. No magical vanishing. They walked to a tasteful black car and drove away.

Shawna ran outside, read the plate, and took a picture.

Then she got into her truck.

"Where are you going?" Aiden asked.

"After the motherfucker."

"We need a plan."

"I have a truck. That's the first half."

Red was already climbing into the cab.

"Move," he told Aiden. "You're holding up my redemption arc."

4. Red Carpet, Blue Blood

They lost Gravitas at the intersection of Sunset and Sunset.

The city had not been built for navigation. It had been built for arriving menacingly.

Aiden directed Shawna left, then left, then left. They passed the same liquor store four times. On the fifth pass, the cashier waved.

"You know him?" Shawna asked.

"That's Rico."

"Since when?"

"Just now. Sign on his shirt."

Red leaned across Tank to study the laptop on Aiden's knees.

"Final Cut. You got an address?"

Darnell, wedged into the truck's rear compartment beside three cones and a roadside emergency kit, had been searching the laptop's open windows.

"They sent an itinerary."

"When?"

"When he clicked the star. They also enrolled him in something."

"Cancel it," Shawna said.

"It says he has to call."

Everyone groaned.

Final Cut Studios stood on a hill behind a pair of enormous gates. Beyond it lay the skyline: glittering towers, palms, smog, and a full moon that looked less convincing the closer they got.

As they approached, a worker on a ladder adjusted one edge of the moon.

Tank rolled down his window.

"Hey."

The worker looked down.

Tank pointed.

"You're crooked."

The worker corrected it.

"Appreciate you."

Aiden stared.

Shawna kept driving.

"You can freak out after we park."

At the gates, a guard in sunglasses held out a hand.

"Invitation."

Red produced his phone.

"Rashad Greene. Executive producer."

Aiden turned toward him.

"You're a what?"

"I agreed to handle promotional opportunities."

"When?"

"There were several quiet seconds while you were looking at the picture."

The guard checked his list.

"Plus four?"

"Creative team," Red said.

The guard looked at the tow truck.

"Very creative."

He waved them through.

Inside, the studio was having a party for itself.

A red carpet ran across a courtyard full of palm trees and men who wore scarves as if their necks were in negotiations. Waiters carried tiny foods

on enormous plates. At a photo wall, a man dressed exactly like Aiden kept holding up one finger and asking photographers to get his good side.

"Who the fuck is that?" Aiden asked.

"Your prestige casting," Red said, reading from the itinerary. "A more relatable leading man."

The man turned.

He looked like Aiden, except expensive.

"Don't engage," Shawna said.

Aiden engaged.

"Are you playing me?"

The actor smiled the way people smile when a stranger identifies them as their problem.

"I'm interpreting the emotional terrain."

"Can you interpret a punch?"

"Aiden," Shawna said.

"What research did you do?"

"I spent an afternoon in a parking structure."

Tank nodded once.

"Method."

The actor noticed Tank and briefly changed his mind about several artistic choices.

Aiden took a step forward. Shawna caught his shirt.

"We came here for T."

"Right."

"You can be vain on the way back."

Red disappeared into the party carrying a stack of unauthorized posters. Darnell followed him toward the control rooms. Shawna took Tank and Aiden around the back.

The first studio door opened onto a street exactly like theirs, except cleaner.

The second opened onto a prison.

The third opened onto the prison's award-season interview suite.

The fourth contained Big T.

He sat in a chair on a revolving platform while a woman applied gray to his beard.

A man with a clipboard was asking about his regrets.

"That I let you motherfuckers near my face."

"Something less literal."

"That I didn't swing earlier."

A makeup artist dabbed at his forehead.

"Can you give us a tear?"

"Can you give me my keys?"

Shawna whistled.

Big T looked over.

For one brief, unguarded second, the relief in his face was larger than his anger.

Then he saw Aiden.

"Oh, you brought the problem."

"I'm getting you out."

"Start with the beard. They aged me twelve years. I ain't even ate lunch."

Tank entered first. The man with the clipboard approached him.

"Sir, this is a closed -- "

Tank picked him up by the belt, turned ninety degrees, and set him gently behind a velvet rope.

The man looked down at the rope, uncertain whether his authority permitted him to cross it.

"Closed," Tank agreed.

Shawna wheeled Big T off the platform.

Aiden grabbed the nearest box of wipes. He pulled one free and tried to remove the gray from Big T's face.

The wipe sparkled.

Big T's cheek sparkled.

They looked at the packet.

MEMORIES OF A FATHER: AGEING & SHIMMER KIT.

"Stop helping," Big T said.

An alarm began.

On a wall monitor, Mr. Gravitas appeared.

"Aiden."

"We're taking him home."

"He has not completed his emotional preparation."

"He's prepared," Shawna said. "His emotion is pissed."

Two black-suited men entered from the far door. Then two more.

Tank looked down at Big T's rolling chair.

"Can you keep your arms in?"

"Why?"

Tank pushed.

The chair flew across the studio.

Big T hit the first guard at knee height. The guard folded onto Big T's lap. They hit the second guard together. The platform chair spun, collecting an extension cord, a curtain, and the clipboard man, who had finally crossed the rope at precisely the wrong moment.

"BRAKES!" Big T shouted.

"Those are your feet!" Tank called.

Shawna drove a wheeled rack of ceremonial jackets into the remaining guards. Aiden ducked a punch, tried to deliver a right hook, and struck a coat hanger.

The pain was immediate and honest.

"Ow! Fuck!"

AIDEN SHRUGGED OFF THE BLOW.

"No I didn't!"

He ducked again and followed Shawna through the service door.

Big T and the chair crashed into a stack of foam tombstones.

On the top one was his own face.

Below it:

HE TAUGHT US HOW TO STAND.

Big T read it, sat up, and broke it over a guard's head.

"Then learn."

They burst into a corridor marked ARCHIVE / CONTINUITY.

Red and Darnell were coming from the opposite direction. Red wore a black lanyard and an expression of financial injury. Darnell carried a metal case, two cables, and a bowl of tiny sausages.

"I found how they do it," Darnell said.

"I found out gross isn't net," Red said. "We are all victims today."

Behind them, the alarm lowered by an octave.

Gravitas's voice filled the hall.

"You are confusing movement with plot."

Shawna looked back.

"Catch up, then."

They ran.

5. The Backstory Department

At the end of the corridor, a security shutter slammed down.

Tank hit the button beside it.

Nothing.

He hit it again, harder.

Nothing.

"Good diagnostic work," Red said.

Tank looked at him.

Red moved away from the shutter.

Darnell pointed to a side door.

BACKSTORIES. AUTHORIZED PAIN ONLY.

Big T kicked it open.

Inside were shelves, floor to ceiling, stacked with boxes.

Some boxes were labeled ABSENT FATHER. Others read PRESENT FATHER, WORSE. A discounted pallet held DEAD WIVES WITH TALENTED HUSBANDS.

Shawna stopped in front of it.

"That's some nasty-ass inventory."

"Don't read the reviews," Darnell said.

At the far wall, three identical boys sat at three identical kitchen tables while three identical mothers told them they were special.

One boy lifted his hand.

"Can I use the bathroom?"

A woman in headphones sighed.

"We talked about this. You're a memory."

"Still gotta go."

She pointed down the hall.

All three boys got up.

Big T watched them leave.

"Even the flashbacks understaffed."

Darnell cleared a table and opened the case.

Inside was a compact projector with a viewing screen, two empty spindle mounts, and a neat little manual.

"This thing runs the city," he said.

"That's it?" Shawna asked.

"This one's a copy. The big one is under tonight's stage."

"Where's the film?"

"He's got the original loop in his silver case. He took it out of the projector. That's why parts of town are starting to disappear. Tonight he's putting in the final scene. Once it plays all the way through, the rough cut gets replaced and tomorrow starts."

Big T leaned over the projector.

"Put in something where I'm not dead."

"That's what I was gonna suggest."

Aiden felt a small, foolish surge of relief.

"So we steal the ending."

"Blank reel in the case," Darnell said. "Marked ALTERNATE ENDING. One of us has to get that into the camera at the lot and record a new finish. Then play it instead of his. We can't just stop his film. The city needs somewhere to go."

"What's a finish?" Tank asked.

Darnell pointed to a page in the manual.

A picture showed the gold clapboard closing, followed by a final frame reading THE END.

"He starts the last take with the board. He ends it with the board. Camera makes the film. Projector makes it stick."

Red held up a finger.

"If we can operate the board and the camera, why do we need the director?"

Darnell looked up.

"That's the whole fucking scam."

For a moment, nobody said anything.

Then Big T smiled.

It was the first smile Aiden had seen from him that day which suggested violence as recreation.

"All right."

A noise came from the shelves behind them.

Aiden turned.

On a box at eye level, in careful handwriting, was his name.

AIDEN. BEFORE.

He knew better than to open it.

He opened it.

Inside lay a child's blue jacket, a cassette tape, a school photograph, and a pair of cheap sneakers with little lights in the heels.

Aiden lifted one shoe.

It flashed.

He remembered running down a hallway in it.

The memory arrived entire: dark carpet, the light in his heel, a woman laughing from the kitchen.

He gripped the shoe.

The others grew quiet behind him.

He pressed the heel again.

The same hallway. The same laugh.

No next moment.

He pressed it once more.

"Aiden," Shawna said.

"I know."

He did not put the shoe down.

A little tag hung from the lace.

BOYHOOD, URBAN, PREMIUM.

Below that, in a different pen:

ALSO APPROVED FOR JAYDEN, KAIDEN, AND RYAN.

Aiden laughed once. It sounded too small for the room.

Big T came over.

He looked into the box.

"They give you light-up shoes?"

Aiden nodded.

"I wanted those. My aunt said the lights would attract kidnappers."

Aiden looked at him.

"Would they?"

"I was eight. I thought kidnappers hunted like moths."

Aiden laughed properly this time.

Big T waited until he put the shoe back.

Then he handed him the box lid.

"We need you for something."

"What?"

"Carrying the damn projector. Tank can't carry everything."

Aiden took it.

The security shutter shook.

Someone outside shouted for them to come out slowly with their hands up and a clearer character motivation.

Shawna climbed onto a chair and pushed at a ceiling panel.

"Tank. Give me a boost."

He put his palms together. She stepped into them, rose, and disappeared into the space above.

A pause.

"There's a corridor up here."

"A vent?" Aiden asked.

"No. A corridor. Carpet. Exit signs."

Darnell nodded.

"Maintenance uses it when the dramatic exits are blocked."

They helped Big T up first. Then Red, who insisted someone hold his coat without creasing it. Darnell passed up the projector and the sausages.

Aiden lingered at the shelf for half a second.

He took the cassette.

Not the shoes. Just the tape.

Then he climbed.

Tank remained below.

The hatch was too narrow for his shoulders.

He studied it.

From above, Big T said, "You fit?"

"No."

"Turn sideways."

"I have tried being wide in other directions."

The door burst open.

Two guards entered, followed by Mr. Gravitas.

Tank looked at the guards. Then at the table. Then at the shelves.

"Careful," Gravitas said. "Most of this is irreplaceable."

Tank picked up a box marked ONLY CHILD.

He threw it.

It burst against the first guard in a spray of birthday cards and unshared toys.

The second guard ducked behind LOST BROTHER and came up crying.

Tank grabbed the top of the shelf and pulled.

A lifetime of father figures, terrible winters, beloved dogs, and one unaccountable violin crashed into the aisle.

Gravitas staggered backward.

Tank climbed the fallen shelving like a ladder, placed both hands against the ceiling, and shoved.

The frame broke.

He hauled himself through as the corridor above filled with plaster dust.

Shawna looked at him.

"You could do that the whole time?"

Tank caught his breath.

"I was trying not to lose the deposit."

They ran down the carpeted passage.

Below them, Gravitas brushed dust from his turtleneck and picked up an open box.

Something moved in his face.

For one dangerous second, it might have become a human expression.

Then he checked the label.

REGRET. MID-LIFE.

He closed the box.

"Cheap," he said.

6. The Ditch

They came out of the maintenance corridor into a room full of interchangeable nightclubs.

Aiden could tell them apart because one was called HEAT, one was called FIRE, and one was called UNTITLED CLUB SEQUENCE, which he considered unusually honest.

Shawna headed straight for the last one.

"Truck's the other way," Big T said.

"Two minutes."

"We don't have two minutes."

"Then you should've let me drive faster."

Inside, a DJ stood behind a table with his headphones pressed to one ear, waiting for someone to tell him what city he was in.

Shawna put her phone beside his mixer.

"Play that."

He looked at her screen.

"That's your own track."

"Well spotted."

"Management says cello until eleven."

Shawna removed his headphones and put them around her own neck.

"Management's having a personal emergency."

She had made the track in her truck over nineteen identical Saturdays. It sampled the turn signal, the air horn, an exhausted starter motor, and Big T shouting DON'T PUT THAT SHIT ON THE PAINT.

The beat dropped.

Three men holding whiskey glasses began, against all their recent expectations, to have a good time.

Shawna grinned.

Aiden saw the grin and forgot the guards for half a second.

She turned a dial.

The cello died.

Every speaker in the studio said DON'T PUT THAT SHIT ON THE --

Then the bass hit so hard a chandelier lost a crystal.

Tank caught it.

"There go the deposit."

They ran before the DJ could ask for his headphones back.

Outside, black-suited men were moving toward the sound. Shawna's private vanity had accidentally become a useful diversion, a development she immediately accepted as her original plan.

At the tow truck, Big T tried the passenger door. Locked.

Shawna opened the driver's side.

"It sticks. Give it a second."

"We being chased by cinema."

"And the truck is nineteen years old. Both things can be true."

They loaded in. Red was still wearing his executive-producer lanyard. Darnell held the little projector between his feet.

Aiden put the stolen cassette into the truck's dashboard.

Shawna slapped his wrist.

"Do not feed strange tapes to my truck."

"It was in my box."

"The box was strange too."

The tape clicked.

A voice filled the cab.

Aiden's voice.

Not the one in the sky. Not the one Aiden used to talk his way into trouble.

This voice sounded tired.

If anyone finds this, my name is Aiden. I made a man because I was embarrassed.

Shawna took her hand off the eject button.

They drove through the studio gates as the voice continued.

Tape One: Aiden's account of an improvement

At first, I could make everyone applaud. I found this reassuring. I mistook it for being good at something.

Then someone asked for a story worth remembering.

I thought the missing ingredient was suffering. My own had been mostly decorative. Bruises, then victory. Losses mentioned after I had already survived them. It seemed unfair that I should have to invent a childhood in order to suffer properly.

So I made someone else.

I called him Grant. He asked why.

I told him I was granting him a life.

He said this was a very self-important way to name a baby.

I liked him immediately.

The truck hit a pothole.

Big T looked at Aiden.

"You been doing this before?"

"I don't remember."

"That's becoming less comforting."

On the tape, a door shut.

I gave Grant a room. I gave him books. I gave him a view of the sea, although I never decided what sea. For his suffering, I gave him a cell.

A second voice spoke.

Younger than Gravitas. Less controlled.

How long?

Twelve years, the recorded Aiden said.

That's a lot.

It will make the escape more powerful.

Will I escape?

Absolutely.

In the passenger seat, Aiden shut his eyes.

He knew the speed of that answer.

Grant asked for a friend. I supplied an older prisoner in the neighboring cell. He asked for a spoon. I supplied a spoon. He asked for the friend's name.

I said the name did not matter yet.

He said it mattered to the friend.

We had our first disagreement.

The tape hissed.

Then Grant said, *Let me tell it. You're doing the walls fine. You're shit with people.*

The story Grant told: The Man in the Sack

The fortress stood on an island so small that its governor had to borrow space from the sea to feel important.

Every morning he walked along the wall, looked at the water, and congratulated himself on the absence of visitors.

In the lowest cell lived a prisoner called Grant, who had been convicted of expecting an answer from someone above him.

His neighbor was a thief named Candle.

"Because you shine in the darkness?" Grant asked through the wall.

"Because I stole candles."

"Ah."

"They keep wanting it to be a metaphor."

For seven years, Candle dug toward Grant with a spoon.

At the end of the seventh year, he broke through the wall.

He looked around Grant's cell.

"Fuck."

They stared at one another.

"Where were you trying to go?" Grant asked.

"Outside."

"You came a bit left."

Candle sat on the floor. He was old, dirty, and so disappointed that Grant began laughing before he could stop himself.

Candle looked offended.

Then he looked at the spoon.

Then he laughed too.

It was the first thing in the fortress that had been done without permission.

After that, they shared everything they had: half a loaf, a little water, a window too high to reach, and the enormous insult of having done seven years' work toward a second prison.

Candle knew a thousand stories. Most had been stolen. He told them slowly because there were a thousand mornings left.

One was a play he had once performed while hiding from an innkeeper.

"Did you write it?" Grant asked.

"I wrote down that it was mine."

He called the play *The Visitor in Yellow*.

Candle's play: The Visitor in Yellow, the surviving scene

An empty throne. A bell. A locked door. Behind the door, the sea can be heard arranging itself.

THE KING: Who is there?

THE VISITOR: A messenger.

THE KING: What do you carry?

THE VISITOR: The ending you ordered.

THE KING: Is the prisoner dead?

THE VISITOR: The prisoner has left his cell.

THE KING: That is not an answer.

THE VISITOR: It is the only answer you paid for.

The King rings the bell. Nothing happens.

THE KING: Why does nobody come?

THE VISITOR: You dismissed the guards for knowing too much.

THE KING: And the servants?

THE VISITOR: You dismissed them for knowing too little.

THE KING: And the audience?

THE VISITOR: You dismissed them for laughing.

The King lowers the bell.

THE KING: Then who is listening?

THE VISITOR: Open the door.

THE KING: Show me your face.

THE VISITOR: Open the door. I have delivered what you asked for.

The King opens the door.

The Man in the Sack, continued

"And then?" Grant asked.

Candle shrugged.

"That's when the innkeeper came back."

"You don't know who's outside?"

"Whoever gets cast."

"You can't just stop a story there."

Candle lay down on his blanket.

"Watch me."

The next morning, he did not wake up.

Grant spent an hour trying to make this the old man's next joke.

He pushed the blanket. He said Candle's name in several tones, as if one would prove difficult enough to ignore. Then he sat beside him and used the spoon to tap on the floor, once, twice, three times.

Nobody answered.

For the first time, Grant hated the sea.

It kept doing the thing it did yesterday.

When the guards came, they gave him a sack and told him to sew Candle inside it.

The fortress permitted only two kinds of departure: the governor's boat, and the dead dropped through a hatch into the water.

Grant stitched slowly.

At Candle's shoulder, he stopped.

The sack was large enough for a man.

The door was guarded by men who did not want to look closely at a body.

He moved Candle onto his own bed. He dressed him in his own jacket. He got into the sack with the spoon and pulled the last stitches shut from inside.

When the guards returned, Grant held still.

They lifted him.

One complained that death made people heavy.

Grant almost laughed. He was terrified that he would.

Up the steps. Through a corridor he had heard for twelve years and never seen. Past a kitchen smelling of onions. Out into a wind large enough to have come from anywhere.

At the hatch, they set him down.

He heard the sea below.

Then the governor spoke.

"Wait."

Boots approached.

A blade touched the sack beside Grant's throat.

"Show me his face."

Tape One, continued

Stop, the recorded Aiden said.

Grant's voice changed.

What?

It's slow.

It's the escape.

We spent seven years on a spoon.

You spent a sentence. I spent seven years.

A long silence.

The real Aiden opened his eyes.

From the driver's seat, Shawna watched the road. She had turned the music off completely.

On the tape, Grant said, *You promised I'd get out.*

The recorded Aiden exhaled.

Can we do something more exciting?

A scrape. A hard click.

For a few seconds, only the tape hiss remained.

Then Grant spoke again.

Very quietly.

The King heard someone at the door.

Something knocked inside the truck's dashboard.

Shawna hit the brake.

Who is there? Grant asked himself.

The ending you ordered.

The cassette deck's plastic face bulged outward.

Big T moved his knees away from it.

Open the door, Grant said. I have delivered what you asked for.

A finger appeared through the slot.

Pale. Clean nail. Black cuff behind it.

Shawna yanked the cassette out.

The finger vanished.

Everybody stopped breathing at once.

Outside, behind them, a black car turned onto the road.

"That's how he got out," Darnell said.

Aiden stared at the tape.

A story inside a story. A messenger arriving at the teller's own door.

And him, somewhere he couldn't remember, opening it.

Tank broke the silence.

"Should've let the man finish with the spoon."

Shawna floored the accelerator.

The truck lurched forward. The black car followed.

At the next turn, the road ended.

Not in a wall or a barrier. It simply stopped being road. Beyond its broken yellow line was white space, bright and depthless.

Shawna swore and hauled the wheel right.

The truck slid down an embankment, smashed through three shrubs, and landed nose-first in the ditch.

Nobody spoke for a second.

Then the old voice in the sky, sensing familiar territory, rallied.

THINGS GOT HEATED IN THE CAR.

"Do not," Shawna said.

COULDN'T WAIT TILL WE GOT HOME.

Big T pulled a chip packet out of his collar.

"I assure you I could."

The black car stopped at the edge of the embankment.

A door opened.

Gravitas stood above them.

He had put on gloves.

"Did you enjoy my story?" he asked.

Aiden climbed out of the truck.

"Grant?"

Gravitas's face tightened.

"That name was given to me by a fool."

"I didn't know."

"You didn't remember."

Shawna had gone around the rear of the truck. She unhooked a chain and passed it to Tank. Neither man at the top of the ditch noticed.

"I asked you to finish it," Gravitas said. "You made another joke. So I finished it myself. I became the man who could make you care."

"By killing T?"

"You remembered Candle for nearly six seconds. I wanted to see how long someone you loved would last."

Big T got out of the cab.

"Put that shit on a complaint form."

Gravitas looked at him.

There was real hate in the look now, ugly and uncomposed.

"You get to be loved for making jokes."

"I also do a very good interior detail."

"Everything is a joke to you."

"No. Some things are forty-five dollars extra."

The chain tightened behind the truck.

Tank nodded to Shawna.

She climbed into the cab and operated the winch.

The truck began to rise backward up the slope. They had connected it to the only thing heavy enough to help them: Gravitas's car.

Gravitas felt the movement through his shoes.

He looked down.

His car slid an inch toward the ditch.

"You wouldn't."

Shawna leaned out of the window.

"I maintain it."

The car's tires squealed.

The tow truck climbed. The sedan slid.

Aiden scrambled onto the step beside Shawna's door. Big T grabbed the rear handrail. Tank stepped calmly onto the bed.

Gravitas ran toward his car as its front wheels went over the edge.

The truck reached the road.

The sedan landed in the ditch with an expensive crack.

Shawna released the line.

Big T looked back.

"YOUR STORY GOT A DENT IN IT."

They drove.

Aiden held the tape in both hands.

Nobody asked him whether he felt real.

For once, he would have preferred that question.



7. Your Presence Is Requested at Your Funeral

They stopped behind Blue Line, where the sky now ended halfway down the neighboring building.

The upper floors were gone. A man stood on what remained of the third-floor landing, holding a laundry basket and staring into the blankness where his bathroom used to be.

"Anybody know if this is temporary?" he called.

"We're handling it," Aiden said.

Five people turned toward him.

"We're attempting to handle it."

"Thank you," Shawna said.

Inside, the mysterious homies were still counting money.

Big T pointed at them.

"Break time."

They cheered.

"Outside."

They left with extraordinary relief. The man who had been pouring Henny came back for his glass, thought about it, and left the glass too.

Darnell put the projector on the desk. Red laid out his promotional itinerary. Tank found a bag of frozen peas for his knee.

Aiden waited for somebody to tell him what to do.

Nobody did.

Shawna went outside with a wrench.

After a moment, he followed.

She lay on a creeper beneath the truck, reaching up into the damage from the ditch.

"Hold this," she said.

He took the flashlight.

"At the bolt."

He moved it.

"That one."

He moved it again.

For a while, he successfully illuminated a bolt.

The work was surprisingly demanding. His arm hurt. He kept wanting to ask whether he was doing it right.

"Do you think I made you too?" he said.

The wrench stopped.

"You asking because you're scared, or because you're about to tell me what my favorite color is?"

"Scared."

"Purple."

"What?"

"Favorite color. Purple. You keep putting me in red because you think it looks hotter."

Aiden looked at the purple lettering on the door.

"I didn't know."

"It's on a fucking truck."

She tightened the bolt.

"I don't remember the tape," he said.

"I believe you."

He exhaled.

"I also believe you made him," she said.

His arm lowered a little.

"Light."

He raised it.

She worked in silence for another minute.

"When did we actually meet?" Aiden asked.

"Outside the nightclub."

"That part's true?"

"You blocked my truck in with your big stupid car."

"I was trying to talk to you."

"I know. You did an entire parking offense to say hello."

"You gave me your number."

"It was the office number."

He remembered the card now. Purple letters. Cars mostly.

"I thought -- "

"You kept calling. At first I thought it was for the car. Then you asked why somebody would start a recovery company. I said the last owner died. You said you were sorry."

Aiden waited.

"I told you he was a bastard and I was just buying his truck. You laughed for about a minute. No line. No trying to make me impressive. You just thought it was funny."

She slid out far enough to look at him.

"That's when I gave you the other number."

He smiled before he could make it useful.

"So I had game."

She rolled back under the truck.

"Move the light, Casanova."

He did.

"I don't know how to stop doing it," he said. "Trying to be the guy who has the answer."

"Try being the guy holding the flashlight."

"For how long?"

"Till I finish the fucking bolt."

He laughed.

She stayed under the truck until the laugh was over.

When she came out, there was grease on one cheek.

Aiden reached toward it, stopped, and showed her his thumb.

She nodded.

He wiped the grease. Mostly he moved it.

"Terrible," she said.

"First draft."

She caught his shirt and kissed him. Briefly, then again without the brevity.

No clothes flew anywhere. A socket fell out of her pocket, rolled under the truck, and became her first concern when they separated.

"That was my good ten millimeter."

"I'll get it."

"I know you will. I just watched it happen."

From inside Blue Line, Big T shouted, "WHICH ONE OF YOU ORDERED A COFFIN?"

Shawna rested her forehead against Aiden's chest.

"Please tell me it's not another improvement."

"Wasn't me."

"Beautiful sentence. Say it again."

Red had ordered the coffin.

He had also ordered a lectern, a banner, a memorial guest book, and four hundred shirts.

BIG T: GONE BUT STILL INTIMIDATING.

Big T held one up.

"When?"

"Early negotiations."

"You looked me in my living eyes and ordered these?"

"The supplier needs lead time."

"I'm going to give you lead time."

"We can put STILL HERE on the back. Pivot."

Tank examined the coffin's wheels.

"This roll good."

Big T glared at him.

"I'm assessing our assets."

Darnell spread a plan of the lot on the table.

The final camera sat on a crane above the central stage. Beneath the stage were the projector and a locked cabinet containing the prepared ending. Gravitas's silver case would hold the source loop and the blank alternate reel. His gold clapboard would be in his hand.

Red tapped the schedule.

"Private rehearsal before the public premiere. Eleven's the audience call."

"We go earlier," Shawna said.

"As what?"

Everyone looked at the coffin.

Then they looked at Big T.

"Absolutely fucking not," Big T said.

Five minutes later, Big T lay in the coffin.

"I want it on record that my objections were detailed."

"They were very clear," Aiden agreed.

The plan was simple in the special sense that the first sentence of a bad plan can be simple.

Red would arrive as the producer with the coffin for the funeral sequence. He would tell Gravitas that Big T had voluntarily returned to complete his emotional preparation. Gravitas would inspect the coffin. While he enjoyed winning, Tank and Shawna would exchange the silver case beneath the lectern for Darnell's identical projector case, weighted with sausages.

The blank reel would go into the portable camera Red had signed out as a publicity expense. The gold clapboard would be replaced by a replica from the merchandise table.

"Then we record our own ending," Aiden said.

"With me alive," Big T said from the coffin.

"With you alive."

"And we do it before midnight," Darnell said.

"And we get my truck out of the final shot," Shawna added. "I don't like how he lights it."

Red looked at Aiden.

"Who's going under the stage?"

"Me."

"You sure?"

"No."

Red nodded.

"That's more promising."

They loaded the coffin onto the truck.

Big T caught Red's sleeve before the lid came down.

"You still got that dumb-ass necklace?"

Red looked at him.

"Which one?"

"The one I gave you. Before all this color-coordinated bullshit."

"It wasn't dumb."

"It was a T. Your name Rashad."

Red glanced away.

"You said it stood for trouble."

"I said it was mine and you could borrow it."

"You gave me a chain and then introduced me to people as the guy borrowing your chain. I bought a red one to shut you up."

"That's why?"

"You thought I organized my entire fucking wardrobe around territorial ideology?"

Big T looked genuinely wrong-footed.

Red adjusted the coffin lining around his shoulder with more care than he had used on the shirts.

"Try not to die in there."

"Why?"

"You still owe me eight hundred."

"Interest is theft."

"You would know."

Red lowered the lid.

For a moment, his hand remained on it.

Aiden noticed.

He was learning that noticing and immediately saying something about it did not have to be the same activity.

The lot had become a cathedral to Big T's presumed death.

There were black drapes, white flowers, two rain machines, and an enormous portrait in which Big T looked as if he had personally discovered forgiveness.

A man tested the stage microphone.

"Loss. Loss. One, two. Loss."

Red walked in first, clipboard in hand.

Behind him, Tank pushed the coffin.

Aiden followed with a box labeled CONDOLENCES, which contained bolt cutters, duct tape, and a packet of sour candy.

Shawna wore an earpiece and the expression of a woman who had already told the headliner where to park.

Gravitas waited beside the lectern.

He looked at the coffin.

Then he looked at Aiden.

"The Man in the Sack," he said.

Aiden's stomach dropped.

Gravitas smiled.

"Do you think I didn't hear my own story?"

The men in black closed the gates behind them.

Inside the coffin, Big T said, "This is why I wanted my objection recorded."

Gravitas lifted the lid.

He and Big T stared at each other.

"Hello, Terrence."

"Don't full-name me in a box."

Gravitas nodded to a guard, who took the CONDOLENCES package from Aiden. Another guard moved toward Shawna.

Tank stepped between them.

Three more guards came from behind the stage.

Gravitas pointed to the chairs.

"Sit. All of you. We can do this with dignity."

Nobody sat.

He pressed a button.

A gunshot cracked overhead.

The enormous portrait of Big T exploded across one shoulder.

For half a second, the hole showed a clean circle of white space beyond the set.

Then the backdrop fluttered and the dark sky returned.

Shawna stopped moving.

The shot had come from a black-suited man on the lighting platform. He held a rifle with none of the old story's glitter or smoke.

Gravitas lowered the remote.

"The practical effects have been upgraded."

Aiden felt his mouth go dry.

The old rough cut had allowed him to take hits and return unchanged. He had asked for consequences. Somewhere inside his stupid request, someone had actually listened.

Gravitas took Aiden's wrist and guided his hand onto the coffin lid.

"You can save your friends some trouble. Take your place. Say the lines. Let one man matter enough to die."

Big T grabbed Aiden's other wrist from inside the coffin.

"Look at me."

Aiden looked.

"Get me out of this fucking box."

It was a much better direction.

Aiden flipped the coffin toward Gravitas.

Big T came out feetfirst.

8. Ten Toes, Nine Problems

The coffin hit Gravitas at the waist. Big T hit him at the chest. They went down in an undignified arrangement of rented velvet and very expensive knitwear.

Tank pushed the lectern into the guard nearest Shawna. She caught the silver case as it slid off the top, missed its handle, and kicked it under the stage instead.

"Aiden!"

He dropped to his stomach and crawled after it.

Above him, boots hammered the boards.

Red shouted, "THE AGREEMENT DOES NOT COVER LIVE AMMUNITION."

Something broke.

Darnell, still outside the gates, began honking the truck's horn.

The old narrator seized its chance.

THE LOT EXPLODED INTO CHAOS. FISTS FLEW. THE AIR WAS THICK WITH --

"We know!" Tank shouted.

Aiden crawled between cinder blocks and cables. The case had stopped beneath the projector stand. He grabbed it, pulled, and discovered its strap caught on a bolt.

He tugged harder.

The projector tilted.

Aiden stopped.

In its little monitor, part of the city tilted with it.

At the edge of the lot, a streetlamp leaned toward the ground.

Very carefully, he put the stand back.

"Okay," he whispered. "Nobody help me for a second."

A hand reached through the curtain around the stage.

Shawna's.

He passed her the case.

A shot hit the boards above him.

Splinters struck his neck.

He lay flat.

For several breaths, all he could hear was the blood in his ears.

Then, very softly, the old ending came to him.

The words were familiar. Easier than moving. One last declaration, one last boast, the last word, and the white flash would return him to the lot before any of this had happened.

He opened his mouth.

Across the dark space beneath the stage, he saw Shawna's boot. She had stayed at the opening, waiting for him to take her hand.

He bit the inside of his cheek and crawled.

She pulled him out.

Big T was rolling across the lot on the coffin's wheeled base, propelled by Tank. Red clung to the rear, using the lid as a shield and shouting that he had always believed in joint ventures.

Gravitas stood by the lectern, one hand on his ribs.

The gold clapboard had fallen beside the coffin.

Aiden scooped it up as Shawna hauled him toward the truck.

"Got it!"

"Don't close it!" Darnell yelled from the gate. "Unless you want to make this shit official!"

The guard on the lighting platform aimed again.

Tank saw him.

A cable ran from the platform to a fan supporting the great black drape that served as the night sky. Tank grabbed the fan's frame and turned it.

The sky blew sideways.

For one bewildering second, the marksman faced a star field coming at him at forty miles an hour.

He stumbled backward, tangled in the cloth, and dropped the rifle.

Tank caught the lower edge of the lighting stand and lowered it as far as his knee would permit. The guard fell the remaining few feet into a stack of memorial cushions.

"For levity," Tank told him.

Shawna rammed the gates with the tow truck.

This time she used the gate.

She was growing as a person.

They piled in. Red refused to abandon the coffin dolly, so Tank lifted the whole thing onto the back of the truck with Big T still lying on it.

"I could get up," Big T protested.

"You could've stayed at work," Tank said.

They drove two blocks before they ran out of blocks.

The road ahead dissolved into blankness. Shawna braked in front of the artisanal liquor store, now reduced to one wall and a man determined to remain premium through the emergency.

Darnell opened the silver case.

The original loop was there.

So was the blank reel.

So was a small explosive charge with a red light.

Aiden stared at it.

"Why?"

Red looked at him.

"Because you asked for real stakes, dickhead."

Shawna closed the case gently.

Nobody breathed.

From the case came a cheerful recorded voice.

"Thank you for choosing Final Cut. Your alternate ending will be available after the death of your mentor."

Big T got up off the coffin dolly.

"He really wants a lot of mileage out of this."

Darnell looked through the gap in the lid.

"There's a light sensor. Open it all the way and -- "

"Then stop opening it," Tank said.

They sat there, six people and an incredibly confident laptop, with their entire city in a booby-trapped briefcase.

Aiden thought of Grant in the sack.

At the point where the escape was supposed to work, the governor had come to look.

Show me his face.

Their first plan had been copied from an unfinished story. Their enemy had waited at the exact place where that story had stopped.

Now they had to do something the prisoner had not got to do.

Aiden looked at Shawna.

"You still got that cover? The one for the truck battery?"

"A tarp?"

"The black one."

She pulled it from behind her seat.

Aiden put it over himself and the case.

"If it's watching for light," he said from underneath, "then it doesn't get any."

"That's either smart or the dumbest last sentence ever," Red said.

Inside the dark, Aiden opened the lid.

No flash. No bang.

He felt for the canisters, his fingertips clumsy with fear. Round metal. The rough label on one, smooth lid on the other.

He took both out.

"Got them."

Big T grabbed his wrist through the tarp.

"Slow."

Together, they pulled the canisters clear. Aiden closed the case before Shawna lifted the tarp.

From inside it, the recorded voice said, "Your trial period has expired." A series of beeps began.

"Darkness bought us time," Darnell said. "Time appears to be over."

He sat in the cold evening air with both reels on his lap and no idea where to put the shaking in his hands.

Big T took one canister from him.

"Good -- "

"Don't," Aiden said too quickly.

Big T looked at him.

"I was gonna say good thing you didn't drop it."

"Right."

Aiden tried to smile.

Big T squeezed the back of his neck once, firmly, and let go.

Shawna put the closed case on the road, backed the truck away, and called to the liquor-store owner to join them.

He arrived carrying the register.

"I will need compensation."

"Get in line," Red said.

They drove behind the surviving corner of Blue Line.

A distant blast rolled through the street.

The truck windows rattled.

A little later, a door handle fell from the sky.

Big T caught it.

He inspected the paint.

"Cheap finish."

They had the original loop, a blank reel, a camera, a projector, and the gold clapboard.

They also had less than a city, no safe road out, and an ending prepared by a man who knew all their favorite tricks.

Darnell loaded the blank reel into Red's borrowed publicity camera.

"We can film from here," he said. "But it needs a whole account. Beginning to ending. If we only give it the last thirty seconds, tomorrow won't know what happened to everything else."

"That's in the manual?" Shawna asked.

He turned it around.

CONTINUITY MUST BE SUPPLIED. DO NOT ASSUME THE AUDIENCE WAS HERE FOR YOUR PRIVATE THOUGHTS.

"Useful book," Tank said.

Aiden took the microphone.

Then he gave it back.

Everyone waited.

"I don't think I should be the only one who talks," he said.

Shawna adjusted the tripod.

"Then don't be. But you've got the beginning."

Across the back lot, Red was inflating a twelve-foot memorial Big T.

The blower whined.

Aiden stared at the rising figure.

"What the hell is that?"

"If we're being watched, I want him looking at a bigger T."

The inflatable's left angel wing caught a spark from the damaged sign overhead and began to burn.

Red beat at it with an unsold shirt.

"It's fire resistant!"

"It's resisting poorly!" Tank called.

Shawna pointed the camera at Aiden and opened the gold clapboard.

She read its inscription: FINAL TAKE.

"No rehearsal," she said.

The slate cracked once.

The camera light came on.

Aiden wiped his mouth.

Shawna looked through the viewfinder.

"From the beginning."



9. The Final Final Cut

"And then," Aiden said into the microphone, "she told him to start from the beginning."

He stopped.

The red light on the camera remained on.

The inflatable Big T had lost one wing and most of its confidence. Behind the truck, the real Big T was listening with his arms folded.

"That's where we are," Aiden said.

"I noticed," Shawna said.

The entire account had taken longer to tell than Aiden expected. They had played the cassette into the microphone when he reached the ditch, stopping before the hand could return. They had argued over the price of a wheel detail. Tank had corrected the angle at which he lifted the clipboard man. Red had interrupted three times to insist that the shirts were not his idea, then twice to request credit for their sales.

Beyond the back lot, the last streetlights went out one by one.

Darnell checked the remaining film.

"Enough for a finish. Not enough for another fucking introduction."

Aiden put the microphone down.

For a moment, all six of them watched the little red light.

Then somebody applauded.

Slowly.

From the alley.

Mr. Gravitas stepped into the light.

The front of his turtleneck had been torn. There was ditch mud on one sleeve and a line of dried blood at his temple.

For the first time that night, he looked as though he had been somewhere.

"You gave me a box of regret," he said.

Aiden stared at him.

"In your account. After you left the archive. You described me picking up a box of regret."

Nobody moved.

"You weren't there."

Aiden looked at the camera.

"No."

"But it was a nice image."

"Yeah."

Gravitas smiled.

"You still can't leave me alone in a room without deciding what I mean."

Aiden looked down.

Shawna kept the camera running.

Behind Gravitas, two black-suited men appeared, one on either side of the alley. The first carried the remote. The second held a gun low against his leg.

Big T unfolded his arms.

Gravitas raised one hand.

"I know. You're going to say something coarse. Everyone will laugh. He'll turn it into a lesson. I'd like to skip that part."

"You got a guy with a gun," Big T said. "I wasn't planning to laugh."

Gravitas looked at Aiden.

"Give me the slate."

It lay beside the camera.

Shawna put her foot over it.

"No."

"You can't save him by filming a better apology."

"I'm not filming an apology," she said. "I'm filming what happens."

The gunman raised his weapon.

Red made a small movement beside the truck. Big T caught it and looked at him.

Red's eyes went toward the inflated memorial, its power cable, the alley, the narrow space between the men in black.

Big T nodded.

He did not ask for the plan.

Red took off his coat.

This upset him visibly.

"All right," Aiden said to Gravitass.

Shawna looked at him.

He shook his head once. He wasn't reaching for the board.

"Tell the rest."

Gravitass stared.

"What?"

"The governor cuts open the sack. What happens?"

"There is no rest. You stopped it."

"What did you want to happen?"

"You think this is the scene where you cure me?"

"No. I think you have a guy with a gun, and I'm asking what happened in the story."

For a moment, Gravitass had no posture available to him.

His eyes moved to the microphone.

"Candle should have lived," he said.

Aiden nodded.

"He was boring. He complained about his knees. He took days to get to the point. Every time he told the play, he made the king more stupid."

Tank shifted the peas against his own knee.

Gravitas noticed and looked away.

"I knew he was making it up."

His voice was almost the young voice on the tape.

"I didn't care."

Behind him, Red fed his expensive coat through the remains of the inflatable's burned wing. He pulled it tight, making a rough sling. Big T stepped closer to the front of the truck, drawing the gunman's attention.

Aiden kept his eyes on Gravitas.

"I can't make the part I did disappear," he said.

"You could try. You've made everything else disappear."

"I don't trust what I'd put there."

Gravitas gave a small, surprised laugh.

It was unpleasant, but it was a laugh.

"Finally."

He reached for the microphone.

The gunman glanced at him.

That was when Red pulled the plug on the blower.

The inflatable Big T began to fall.

Not fast enough.

Red saw the gunman turn back.

He threw himself backward with the coat wrapped around his arms and dragged twelve feet of memorial vinyl across the alley.

The inflatable hit the first man in the face. The second fired into the enormous blue chest looming over him.

Air roared from the holes.

Big T charged.

Tank caught the armed man's wrist against the truck door. Shawna kicked the gun under the chassis. Darnell drove the coffin dolly into the other man's ankles.

The camera tilted.

Aiden caught it before it hit the ground.

In its viewfinder, Gravitas ran.

Not away from them.

Toward the lot.

He had taken the microphone.

The cable snapped taut, pulled free, and trailed behind him like an indignant tail.

Shawna scooped up the gold clapboard.

"Camera!"

Aiden held it up.

"Still going!"

"Get in!"

Tank secured the two dazed men with the remains of Red's coat while Red said things to him that would have permanently reduced the value of the audiobook.

The liquor-store owner emerged from behind a tire rack.

"I can watch them."

He held the register in both hands like a brick.

Big T considered him.

"Don't hit nobody unless you have to."

The man nodded.

"Premium service."

They drove toward the lot.

There were no streets left except the route back. On either side, front doors opened into blankness. A dog stood at the threshold of an absent house, holding its own leash.

Shawna braked.

"No," Big T said.

She opened the door.

The dog jumped in.

"We don't have time!"

"It was right there!"

The dog put its paws on Big T's lap.

He looked down.

"Don't do that."

The dog did that.

They continued.

At the lot, Gravitass was already onstage.

The premiere audience had arrived. Customers from Blue Line. Workers from the studio. The men who counted money. The little girl with the balloon, accompanied by the cashier from the ordinary liquor store. Three identical boys who had found their way out of the Backstory Department and were sharing a packet of chips.

They sat facing the screen because every other direction contained less and less of the world.

The stage clock read 11:56.

Gravitass stood at the lectern with the microphone plugged into a spare jack.

"There will be a short delay," he announced.

A man in the front row raised his hand.

"Can the delay have music?"

Gravitas ignored him.

He looked past the audience as Shawna's truck came through the wrecked gates.

"You need my projector," he said.

Aiden got out with the camera still running.

"We have one."

"You have a viewer. This one is connected to the city."

Darnell swore softly.

The large projector sat under the stage beside the cabinet, which stood open now. Gravitas's prepared reel was threaded through it, waiting behind a closed shutter. A thick cable ran from the projector into the white space behind the set.

Gravitas held up the remote.

"At midnight, I play the ending I prepared. If Terrence is still alive, your world will be corrected to match it. You can record whatever you like."

He stepped toward the cabinet.

Big T started forward.

A gunshot struck the ground between them.

The man from the lighting platform had found another weapon.

He stood above the stage, one arm in a sling, visibly unhappy about his career.

Aiden held the camera against his shoulder.

The audience had started to duck behind the chairs.

Shawna looked from the projector to the curtain beneath the stage.

Then to the tape sticking out of Aiden's pocket.

She held out her hand.

Aiden understood only after he gave it to her.

"Wait."

"You said he got out through the door."

"We don't know where it goes."

"He does."

She climbed into the truck and pushed the cassette into the deck.

Fast-forward.

Click.

The speaker crackled.

The King heard someone at the door.

Onstage, Gravitas stopped.

Who is there?

Beneath the stage, a small yellow rectangle appeared in the dark curtain.

A door.

Old wood. Iron latch. Water creeping beneath it.

The audience turned toward the sound.

The trapped story had been played into a room full of listeners.

This time, it had somewhere large enough to arrive.

The ending you ordered.

Gravitas hurried toward the edge of the stage.

"Turn that off."

Shawna opened her window.

"Come do it."

Open the door, Grant's younger voice said. I have delivered what you asked for.

The latch rose.

Aiden handed the camera to Red and ran.

The gunman swung toward him.

Tank kicked the nearest rain-machine hose toward the platform. Big T seized the loose nozzle and opened it.

A jet of water hit the gunman in the chest.

He fell backward onto the rigging, still firing into the air. The fake moon burst with an embarrassed pop.

The audience screamed, then applauded, then reconsidered the applause.

Aiden reached the yellow door and pulled it open.

Cold salt water spilled across his shoes.

Beyond it, a stone passage descended toward the sea.

For a second he heard a spoon tapping on a wall.

Then Gravitas hit him from the side.

They crashed through the doorway together.

Red, running behind them with the camera, stopped at the threshold.

He looked down the passage.

"I paid for a crime picture," he said.

Then he followed.

Inside the story inside the tape inside the story Aiden had been telling into the camera, the air smelled of onions.

There was no room left for another level of anything. Red felt this strongly.

Grant's cell lay to the left. The governor's steps rose to the right.

Gravitas got to his feet.

He knew the place so well that his body turned toward the cell before he could prevent it.

Aiden stood between him and the doorway.

"You don't have to go back in."

"Move."

"I'm not putting you in the cell."

"MOVE."

Aiden moved.

Gravitas walked past him.

At the cell door, he stopped.

On the bed lay the outline of a man beneath a blanket.

The camera could not get close enough to tell whether it was Candle, a rolled coat, or simply the place where Grant had been made to wait for somebody to keep a promise.

Red did not try.

Gravitas put one hand against the doorframe.

Outside, the stage clock chimed once.

11:58.

Water flowed past their feet.

"I thought if it ended properly," Gravitas said, "I wouldn't have to keep being here."

Aiden stood beside him.

"I don't know how to end that part."

"Of course you don't."

They stood there.

For once, Aiden did not fill the silence.

Behind them, Red shifted the heavy camera.

"I can stand here another minute," he said. "After that, we all drown in a fucking short story."

Gravitas laughed before he could make it cruel.

He covered his face with one hand.

Then he looked toward the kitchen.

The smell of onions.

The door had been open all along in Candle's story, but Grant had never reached it. He had been carried past it in a sack, waiting for a governor to decide whether his escape was good enough.

Gravitas stepped away from the cell.

"Not those stairs," he said.

He pointed through the kitchen.

"The servants have another way out."

Red adjusted the camera.

"They always do."

They ran through the kitchen and out through a narrow service door into the space under the stage.

Behind them, the yellow doorway trembled.

Gravitas pulled it shut.

He did not lock it.

Darnell crawled under the stage to meet them.

"Fifty seconds," he said.

Aiden pointed to the prepared ending.

"That one out. Ours in."

"You gotta finish recording first."

Above them, something crashed. Big T shouted Shawna's name.

Aiden froze.

He had heard Big T irritated, angry, boasting, frightened in a way he covered with volume.

This was different.

Aiden scrambled out from beneath the stage.

The lighting platform had partially collapsed. A support had fallen across the truck's rear bed. Shawna stood on the stage, caught between a stretched cable and the tilted rail of the camera crane. The rain water had made the boards slick.

Big T was holding the crane upright.

Tank was beside him, shoulders under the beam, his bad knee shaking.

Shawna tried to climb through the gap.

The crane shifted.

"Don't move," Big T said.

"That's not an exit plan," she said.

Her voice was steady until the last word.

Aiden grabbed the beam.

It was heavier than the story had ever allowed anything to be.

He pulled.

Nothing.

Red set the camera on the hood of the truck, pointed at the stage. The little red light stayed on.

Then he joined them.

Darnell disappeared back beneath the platform to reach the projector.

Gravitas stood at the edge of the stage.

For a moment, Aiden could see him considering the shape of it: the young man struggling, the woman trapped, the mentor bent beneath a weight he could no longer hold.

It would have been very easy to call it beautiful.

"Grant!" Aiden shouted.

Gravitas looked at him.

"Pick a fucking end!"

He picked the heavy one.

Together, the five men lifted.

Ten feet against wet boards. Ten shoes in ridiculous positions. Tank gritted his teeth. Red's loafers skidded. Big T made a sound Aiden had never heard come from him and hoped never to hear again.

The beam rose an inch.

Shawna ducked beneath it.

Another inch.

She pulled her jacket free, stumbled, caught the stage rail, and jumped clear.

"Out!"

They let go.

The crane crashed through the stage with a noise so large that the old narrator tried to claim it.

AND THAT'S HOW WE --

Shawna slammed the truck's air horn.

The voice stopped.

She stood shaking beside the hood.

Aiden reached her.

For a second he had nothing to say.

She grabbed his hand.

"Keep that," she said.

Then she shoved the gold clapboard into it.

The stage clock began the last ten seconds.

Aiden looked at the camera.

At Big T, leaning against Red without pretending he wasn't.

At Tank sitting hard on the coffin dolly.

At Grant, staring at his torn sleeve.

At Shawna, whose hand was still on his.

He turned the slate around.

On its back was the final title.

THE END.

He closed it.

The camera stopped.

Darnell sprinted from beneath the wreckage, caught the reel as Red pulled it from the camera, and vanished under the stage again.

There was no time to develop it. There never had been; in this city, things became pictures faster than anyone could decide whether they liked being in them.

The projector rattled.

The prepared death scene fell into the water.

The alternate reel turned.

On the screen, Aiden sat in the truck and asked which beginning.

The film raced through its account: the punch, the tango, the burning cash, Shawna at the mixer, a spoon against stone, the truck rising from the ditch, Big T falling out of his own coffin, the camera watching people who were no longer waiting to be told where to stand.

Then the beam.

The hands.

The clapboard.

The last frame passed through the light.

The clock reached midnight.

The screen went white.

Nobody moved.

Aiden tasted blood.

He waited for the punch.

Instead, somewhere beyond the lot, a garbage truck reversed.

Three ordinary electronic beeps.

The streetlights came back on.

Behind the houses, the sky continued into a distance nobody had bothered to paint.

The little girl began to cry. The cashier picked her up. One of the identical boys asked whether anybody knew which mother was his.

Big T raised his head.

"It's tomorrow?"

Darnell looked at his phone.

"Sunday."

Big T shut his eyes.

"Thank fuck."

The audience applauded.

This time, nobody reconsidered.

10. Good Work, Aiden

On Sunday afternoon, Shawna played her first real set behind Blue Line. It was not a celebration of the triumph of the human spirit. It was a party because Red had rented the speakers for three days and could not get a refund.

Aiden stood near the front.

The track began with the truck's turn signal.

Then the reluctant starter.

Then Big T's voice, cut up and pitched down until it sounded like the world's angriest bass instrument.

DON'T PUT THAT --

DON'T PUT THAT --

DON'T --

The drop hit.

Big T, carrying a tray of food, stopped in the doorway.

"That's me."

"We know," everyone said.

"I didn't authorize that."

Red raised a hand.

"We should talk about publishing."

Big T kept walking.

Tank sat in a lawn chair with his knee propped up. The dog slept beside him. Nobody had agreed on a name, because Aiden had begun to suggest one and five people had stopped eating to look at him.

Grant sat at the far end of the yard.

He had come back because Red said he had found his coat. The coat had been retrieved from the two men tied up behind Blue Line. It was not

Grant's coat. It was Red's ruined one. Red had argued that this made it narratively appropriate for Grant to pay for it.

The argument had lasted long enough for Big T to put a plate in Grant's hands.

He was still holding it.

Nobody had asked him to make a speech. Nobody had said they forgave him. Shawna had seated him where she could see him and put the remote in a locked toolbox.

Big T passed him on the way to the grill.

"Eat before it gets cold."

Grant looked at the food.

"What is it?"

"Chicken."

"How was it prepared?"

Big T turned.

Grant's mouth twitched.

"I'm being annoying on purpose."

"Then stop till I've eaten."

At the mixer, Shawna watched Aiden through the change between tracks.

He smiled at her.

She cupped a hand to her ear.

Well?

He waited until she came down from the little platform.

"The starter motor," he said. "Right before the bass. It sounds like the song almost gives up."

She looked at him.

"I love that part."

"Me too."

"You kept the weird pause," Aiden said.

"It's long on purpose."

"It's still too long."

"Aiden."

"But then the truck starts."

She smiled, pleased despite herself.

He put his hands on her waist. She put one hand on his shoulder and used the other to correct a loose cable on the table behind him.

"You coming Monday?" she asked.

"Where?"

"Open decks at the club. No apocalypse. I get twenty minutes."

"Yeah."

"Don't say it if you're going to get busy inventing a new dad."

"I'll come."

She kissed him and went back to the mixer.

Near the grill, Red unfolded a blue towel.

Inside it lay a little gold T on a chain.

The chain had been cleaned. The clasp had been repaired.

He looked toward Big T.

Big T was concentrating very hard on a piece of chicken.

"Thought you said it was borrowed," Red said.

"You kept it this long."

Red put the necklace on beneath his shirt.

"Repair's crooked."

"Then give it back."

Red went to get a plate.

Aiden found the small viewer in the office after dinner.

The reel was still warm from where Darnell had tested a copy.

He watched a minute of the opening. His own face in the truck. The blood on his thumb. The part where he asked to sound objective.

He almost turned it off.

Then he let it run.

Shawna came into the doorway.

"Watching yourself?"

"Checking the ending."

"Come dance with me, dickhead."

He looked past her.

Tank was trying to persuade the dog to move off his good leg. Red was taking photographs that carefully excluded the ruined coat. Grant and Darnell were arguing over whether thunder needed a soundboard. Big T had put his hand over the grill lid to prevent anybody from offering advice.

Aiden switched off the viewer.

Outside, Big T called his name.

"Come help me with this."

Aiden went.

The back wheel of the grill had caught in a crack in the concrete. Big T had been attempting to resolve this through authority.

Aiden lifted one corner while Big T pulled.

The wheel came free.

"Good work, Aiden."

Aiden looked at him.

Big T waited.

"Thanks," Aiden said.

Then he went back to Shawna before either of them could turn moving a grill into a whole thing.

She had started the track again.

Everybody complained about hearing it twice.

Nobody left.

FINAL CUT STUDIO NOTICE, delivered the following morning:

The foregoing production exceeded its authorized scope. Please remit payment for one moon, two security uniforms, a metaphorical sea, and the permanent loss of a properly motivated protagonist.

Handwritten reply by T. Booker:

Come by Monday. Bring the fourteen vans.

After the credits

This is a new ChatGPT-written comic adaptation for Nolan, built from the two supplied PDFs. It is a separate creative version, not a claim that Nolan wrote the generated prose. The original fanfic supplies the recklessly confident Aiden, Big T, Shawna, Red, Tank, the repeated fight, the ditch, and the catchphrases. The later novel supplies useful expansions including Blue Line and several fuller names. This version deliberately changes occupations, relationships, causality, and genre mechanics.

The literary techniques are borrowed at the level of structure: a creator's account enclosing his creation's testimony, as in [Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein*](#); an embedded play intruding upon the world of its listeners, drawing on [Robert W. Chambers's *The King in Yellow*](#); and imprisonment, substitution, disguised return, and revenge, drawing on [Alexandre Dumas's *The Count of Monte Cristo*](#). The miniature prison story and play here are newly written, not passages from those books.

11. Process reflection: Both supplied works were examined, with independent full reads distributed across the writing review. The governing revisions were Nolan's requests for a profane parody of a parody, consequential nested stories, and relationships carrying the conflict. The source PDFs remain separate. A dedicated continuity pass checked the framing camera, borrowed props, timing, and payoff chains.

12. Second reflection: The main risk is that the film machinery occasionally explains more than the comedy needs. The strongest test is whether the prison tale changes the rescue, the rescue changes the telling, and the telling forces Aiden to hear other people. The romantic scenes aim for mutual appetite and inconvenience rather than a perfect woman repairing a foolish man. The remaining judgment belongs to the reader: whether the jokes land and the affection feels earned.